Chapter 3: Identify Real Customer Pain

Finding a person with a plausible problem is not the same as finding a problem worth solving. This chapter shows you how to judge how much a problem matters before you invest more time.

An interesting idea versus a problem people want solved

People will say "that sounds cool" about nearly anything. A **problem people actively want to solve** looks different. It tends to show up as one or more of:

- **Effort already spent:** they built a spreadsheet, hired someone, or cobbled together several tools.
- **Money already spent:** they pay for a tool, a freelancer, or a service.
- **Repeated complaint:** they bring it up more than once, unprompted.
- **Visible cost:** lost time, lost income, missed deadlines, or stress they can name.
- **Active searching:** they ask others for recommendations or alternatives.

If none of those appear, the problem may be real but low priority. A low-priority problem is a hard thing to sell a solution to.

Step 1: Map the current workflow

Write down, step by step, what the person does today to get the job done. Where you can't see a step, mark it as unknown.

For QuoteFlow, Dev's hypothetical map of a contractor's workflow:

1. Visit the property and take notes (phone notes or paper).
2. Return home or to the truck and calculate materials and labor.
3. Type or write the estimate in a template.
4. Send it by email or text.
5. Wait for a reply.
6. Follow up (or forget to).

Dev now sees at least three places a problem might hide: step 3 (time to write), step 4 (professionalism of the document), and step 6 (follow-up). He doesn't know which one, if any, hurts. Good. He knows what to ask.

Step 2: Find current solutions and workarounds

List everything the prospect uses or could use:

- Dedicated software (competitors)

- General tools used creatively (spreadsheets, documents, chat assistants)
- People (assistants, bookkeepers, freelancers)
- Doing nothing, or doing it manually

A workaround is stronger evidence than a complaint. Complaining is free. Building a spreadsheet takes effort.

Step 3: Look for evidence of urgency, inconvenience, cost, or lost time

Ask yourself of every post or conversation:

- Is there a cost? (Money, time, missed opportunities.)
- Is there a deadline or trigger? (Seasonal rush, new regulation, a bad experience.)
- Do they describe consequences? ("I lost a job because the quote was late.")
- How often does it happen? (Daily problems matter more than annual ones.)

Weak versus stronger evidence

Weaker evidence	Stronger evidence
"That would be nice."	"I currently pay someone to do this."
A like or upvote on a related post	A detailed description of their last attempt to fix it
One person complaining once	Several unrelated people describing the same issue
A complaint about a competitor's price	A switch from one tool to another because of a specific issue
Interest in the idea	Willingness to try it now, share data, or pay
Your friends say it's useful	Strangers in your segment describe the problem unprompted

Evaluating public complaints without jumping to conclusions

A public complaint is a lead, not a conclusion. Before you act on one, consider:

- **Who is complaining?** A vocal minority can look like a crowd.
- **Is it a feature request or a pain?** "I wish it had dark mode" is not a problem you solve with a new product.
- **Is the complaint about price or about value?** People complain about prices of things they use heavily, too.
- **Is it recent?** A two-year-old complaint may be solved.

- **Is it a venting post?** Venting does not always mean they'd pay or switch.

Problem-evidence worksheet

Copy this for each segment.

Question	What I found	Source	Strength (weak / moderate / strong)
What is the current workflow?			
What workarounds do people use?			
What do they pay for today?			
What cost, time, or loss do they describe?			
How often does the problem occur?			
Is there a trigger or deadline?			
How many separate people described this?			
What contradicts my assumption?			

Always fill in the last row. If you can't find any contradicting evidence, you probably haven't looked hard enough.

Hypothetical example: Sam and ReviewReply

(Hypothetical.) Sam searches for coffee shop owners discussing online reviews. He finds:

- Several owners saying replying to reviews is something they "know they should do" but rarely get to.
- One owner saying they started ignoring reviews because angry ones felt personal.
- Nothing about paying anyone to handle it.
- A few owners saying their reviews barely influence customers.

Sam's honest reading: there is some pain (time, emotional weight) but weak evidence of spending or urgency, and some owners contradict the assumption that reviews matter. This is moderate evidence at best. He doesn't abandon the idea. He decides to test in conversations whether any owners treat reviews as important enough to act on, and whether a narrower group, such as owners of shops in competitive areas or with recent complaints, cares more.

Decision process: continue, narrow, or reconsider

After gathering evidence, choose one:

Continue if you find several independent people describing the problem, some effort or spending already directed at it, and a reachable group. Move to conversations (Chapters 4 and 5).

Narrow if the problem appears strongly in one subgroup but weakly elsewhere. Example: Sam finds that owners of busy shops with many reviews feel more pressure than owners of tiny shops. Redefine the segment and repeat Chapter 2.

Reconsider if you find little evidence of pain, little effort or spending, and people already satisfied with simple alternatives. Reconsidering can mean a different segment for the same product, a different problem the product could solve, or a different product altogether. It doesn't mean you failed. It means you found out cheaply.

Write your decision and the reason in one sentence. Revisit it after the conversations in Chapter 5.

Chapter 3 action checklist

- [ ] Mapped the current workflow for my segment, marking unknown steps.
- [ ] Listed current solutions and workarounds.
- [ ] Filled in the problem-evidence worksheet.
- [ ] Classified my evidence as weak or stronger.
- [ ] Recorded evidence that contradicts my assumptions.
- [ ] Chose to continue, narrow, or reconsider, and wrote why.

Chapter 4: Start Conversations Without Spamming

The goal of your first message is not to sell. It is to start a relevant conversation that is useful to the other person.

If selling makes you uncomfortable, that is a useful instinct. It will help you avoid the behaviors that make outreach feel awful: generic pitches, fake familiarity, and pressure.

What spam is, and what it isn't

Spam is not defined by how many messages you send. It is defined by relevance and respect. A message is spam-like when it:

- Is identical to many others.
- Pretends to know the recipient.

- Mentions nothing real about them.
- Asks for something big before offering anything.
- Ignores a "no."

A single, short, honest message to someone with a specific, visible problem is not spam, even if it's unsolicited.

A simple framework for a first message

Use these four parts, in this order:

1. **Real observation:** One specific, true thing about them or their situation.
2. **Why you're writing:** Your honest connection to the topic, in one sentence.
3. **Small, easy ask (or small gift):** Something that takes them under two minutes, or a useful piece of information.
4. **Easy out:** A line that makes "no" comfortable.

Keep it short. Most first messages should be under 100 words.

Choose the right channel

Channel	Best for	Watch out for
Public reply	Someone asked a question or described a problem publicly	Self-promotion rules; reply to help, not to pitch
Direct message	Someone who invited contact or where the platform allows it	Platform restrictions; don't DM people who haven't opened the door if the rules forbid it
Email	Business owners and professionals with a public business address	Regional rules on commercial email; honest subject lines; an unsubscribe or opt-out option where required
Introductions	Warm connections through someone you know	Don't spam your network; ask for introductions only where it genuinely makes sense

Template 1: Relevant public reply

When to use: Someone publicly asked how to solve the problem your product addresses.

Personalize: Their actual situation and what they said they tried.

Example (ClipNotes, hypothetical):